

Coleus forskohlii syn. *Plectranthus barbatus* (Lamiaceae)

Coleus

Native to India, coleus is used in Indian folk medicine rather than within the Ayurvedic tradition, and is a traditional digestive remedy. It shot to fame in Western medical circles when one of its constituents, forskolin, was first isolated in the 1970s. Research by an Indian/German company showed that forskolin was a powerful medicine for various conditions, including heart failure, glaucoma, and bronchial asthma.



Coleus is strongly aromatic and the leaves have a distinctive camphor-like scent.

Habitat & Cultivation

Native to India, coleus grows on the dry slopes of the Indian plains and in the foothills of the Himalayas. It is also found in subtropical or warm

temperate areas, including Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar (Burma), and parts of eastern Africa. Coleus was popular as an ornamental in the 19th century. Today it is cultivated on a large scale in Gujarat, India, for use in pickles—around 980 tons (1,000 tonnes) are harvested each year. The plant is propagated by stem cuttings or root division in spring or summer and flourishes in well-drained soil in sun or partial shade. Both root and leaves are harvested in autumn.

Related Species

Six other species of *Coleus* have been investigated but only *C. forskohlii* contains forskolin. Indian borage (*C. amboinicus*) is used traditionally

within Ayurvedic and Unani Tibb herbal medicine to help reduce inflammation and is prescribed for bronchitis and asthma.

Key Constituents

- Volatile oil
- Diterpenes (forskolin)

Key Actions

- Lowers blood pressure
- Antispasmodic
- Dilates the bronchioles (small airways of the lungs)
- Dilates the blood vessels
- Heart tonic

Research

- **Forskolin** The active constituent forskolin was first isolated in the 1970s. It has important therapeutic benefits, which include lowering high blood pressure, relaxing smooth muscle, increasing the release of hormones from the thyroid gland, stimulating digestive secretions, and reducing pressure within the eye.
- **Whole herb** Research into coleus has focused on the action of forskolin in isolation, and the herb as a whole has not been researched.



Coleus

An aromatic perennial, with tuberlike roots and an erect stem, reaching 2 ft (60 cm).

Traditional & Current Uses

■ **Traditional uses** Coleus is a traditional herb in India for a wide range of digestive problems. It is given to relieve gas, bloating, and abdominal discomfort.

■ **Circulatory remedy** An important heart and circulatory tonic, coleus is used to treat congestive heart failure and poor coronary blood flow. It also improves circulation of blood to the brain.

■ **Respiratory problems** Its antispasmodic action makes coleus valuable for respiratory complaints, including asthma and bronchitis.

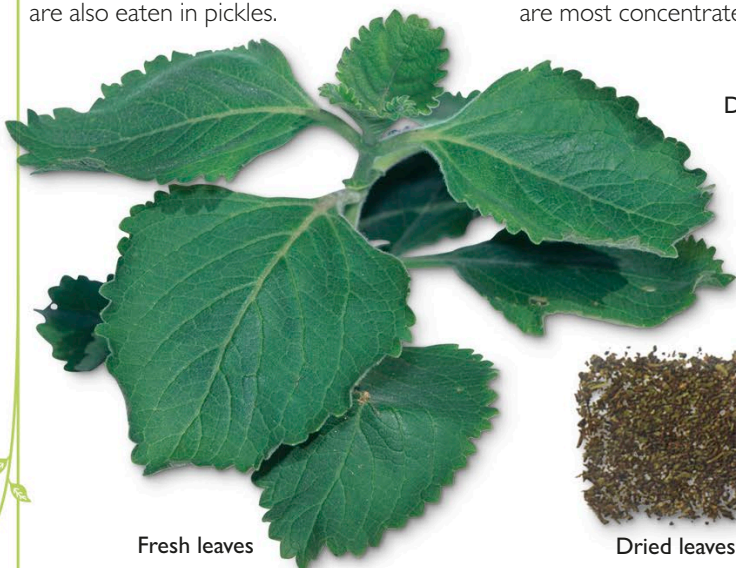
■ **Glaucoma** Coleus is used topically in treatments to relieve glaucoma (excess pressure within the eye, which, if untreated, can result in loss of vision).

■ **Weight loss** Recently, coleus has been marketed as a weight-loss aid. It is argued that because coleus stimulates cellular metabolism, it will help to promote weight loss. There is no evidence to support this, though it may be of use if weight gain is due to poor thyroid function.

Parts Used

Leaves have valuable medicinal properties and are also eaten in pickles.

Root is unearthed in autumn when the active constituents are most concentrated.



Dried root

Fresh leaves

Dried leaves

Key Preparations & Their Uses

⚠ **Cautions** Do not take for circulatory problems or glaucoma without professional advice.



Decoction of the root. For bronchial asthma, make a decoction with 15 g root and 2 cups (500 ml) water (see p. 291). Drink in small doses over 2 days.



Infusion of the leaves (to make, p. 291). To relieve gas and bloating, drink $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) twice a day.